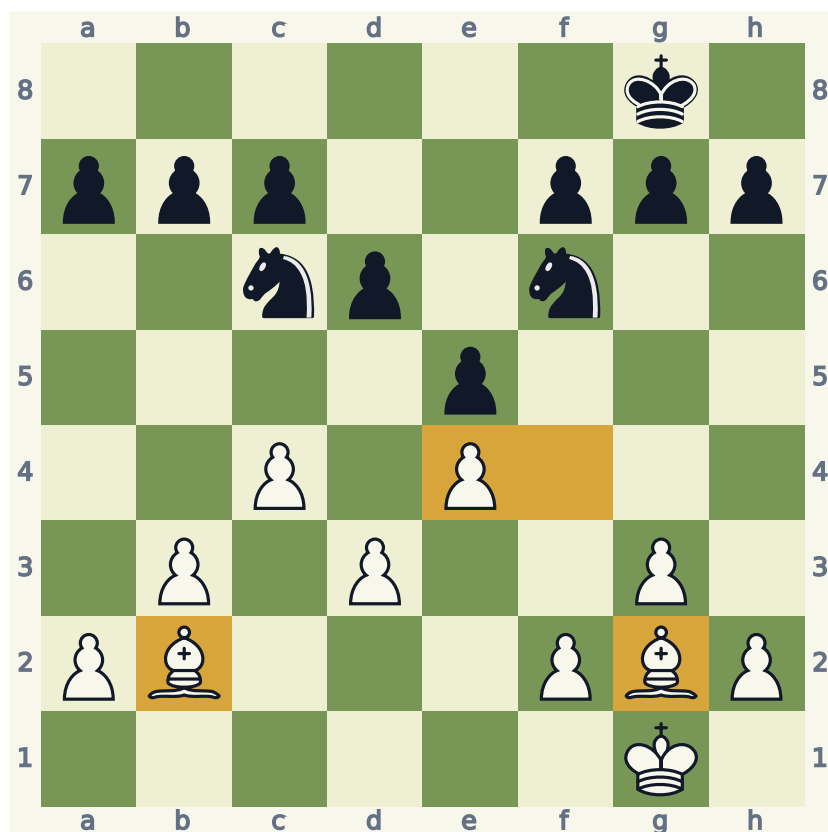


Bishop pair and color complexes

Control both colors, then create entry squares.

Two bishops can cover both color complexes and cooperate over long distances. Their strength increases when pawn breaks open lines. A color complex is a network of squares of one color that can become hard to defend, especially after its bishop is exchanged. Look for accessible squares, not merely missing bishops.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- Bb2's long diagonal meets Black's e5-pawn.
- f4 invites that pawn to leave the diagonal.
- Opening a diagonal also changes the white king shelter.

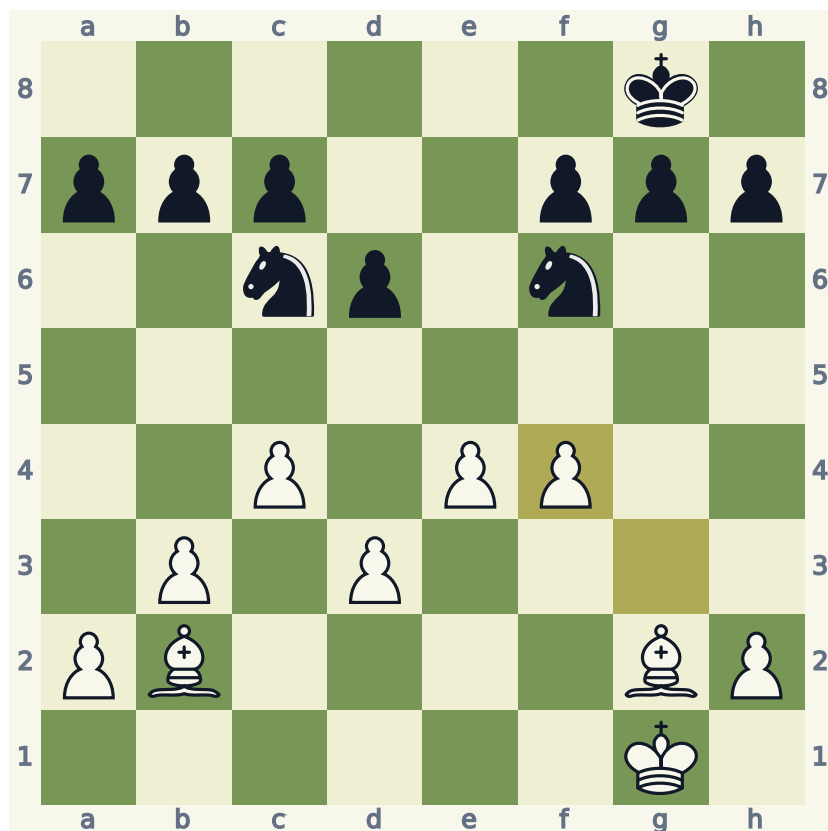
REMEMBER

- Check the color of the actual squares.
- Open lines only when your pieces benefit.
- A weakness needs an attacker and access.

Follow the logic

1. f4 exf4 2. gxf4

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



f4

Create contact with e5. The goal is to open lines for bishops, not just gain kingside space.

...exf4

Black chooses to release the center. This reply is illustrative; Black can also consider keeping the tension.

gxf4

White gains a mobile pawn on f4 and opens the g-file. Bb2 now directly pressures Nf6. Bg2 remains blocked by White's e4-pawn, so the two bishops have different levels of activity.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black should seek stable knight posts and avoid opening every diagonal without a reason. White must check whether the opened g-file helps the attack or exposes Kg1 to future rook play.

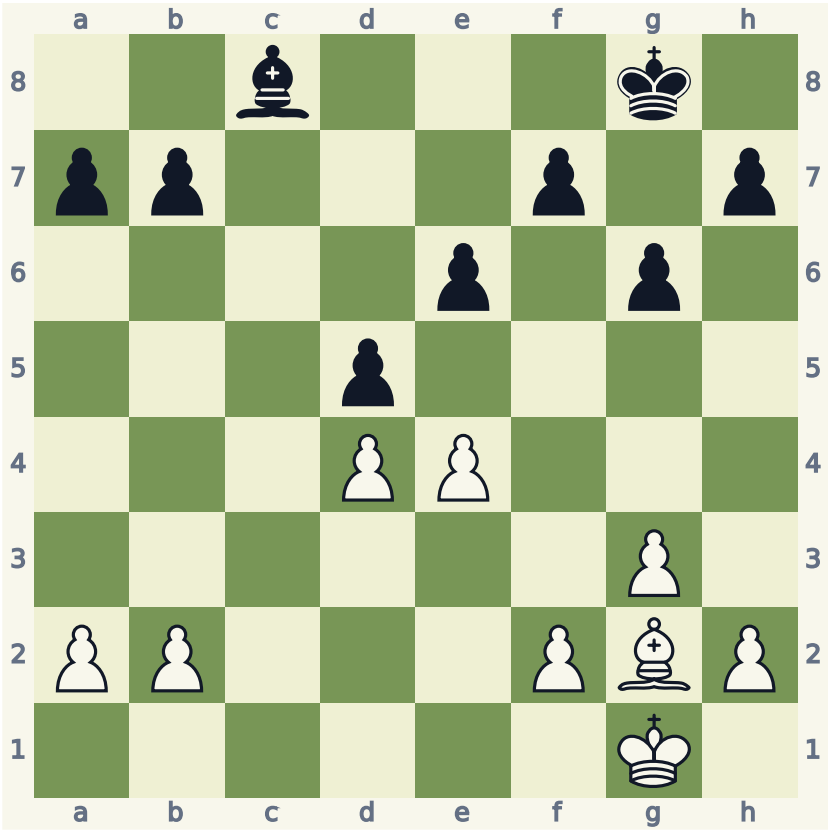
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

The bishop pair is a potential asset, not a fixed extra point of material. If the center remains locked and knights gain secure posts, the bishops may struggle to prove their value.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. What color squares did Black weaken with ...g6?
- 2. Which white bishop could use those squares?
- 3. Why is e5 useful to examine, and what does it concede?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If White had a dark-squared bishop instead, would the weak squares automatically be exploitable?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 2b3k1/pp3p1p/4p1p1/3p4/3PP3/6P1/PP3PBP/6K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. With g7 vacated, dark squares such as f6 and h6 can become more sensitive. Black's light-squared bishop cannot directly defend dark squares, but the king and pawns still matter. A weak color complex does not imply a forced attack.
2. Bg2 is a light-squared bishop and cannot directly occupy f6 or h6, which are dark. The exercise tests whether you check square colors rather than automatically aim a fianchettoed bishop at every weakness.
3. e5 closes the center and gains space, but places another white pawn on a dark square and leaves Bg2 behind the d5 barrier along its main diagonal. Any plan to exploit dark squares would require king activity later or another piece, not this bishop alone.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. e5 Kf8

Changed feature: No. You would still need an entry route and concrete targets. Pawn control, king defense and the time needed to transfer the bishop determine the practical value.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Mark the color of every central pawn and both bishops in one position. Find one pawn move that improves a bishop and one that restricts it.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 08, 14, 21. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.